

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Restaurant Serving English



Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Restaurant servers, food runners, and dining-room service staff.

All people, prices, policies, counts, and incidents are fictional language practice, not food-safety, allergy, alcohol-service, legal, or payment-processing training. Follow workplace training and local requirements. Ingredient and cross-contact questions need the designated kitchen lead; do not guarantee suitability. This course concerns table service, not restaurant management.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

Open this course on [English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

a la carte

Ordered as a separate menu item with its own price.

allergen

A substance that can trigger an allergic reaction; restaurant staff must check the relevant food information.

check-back

A brief return to the table to ask whether the food and service meet the guest's request.

course

One stage of a meal, such as a starter or main dish.

cover

One diner counted for restaurant table service.

cross-contact

Unintended transfer of an allergen between foods or food-contact items.

crumb

A small loose piece of food, especially bread, on a table or plate.

dietary preference

A person's food choice or avoidance that is not necessarily an allergy.

estimated wait

An approximate time before an item is expected, not a guarantee.

fire

A kitchen instruction to begin preparing a course; its exact use varies by restaurant.

handover

A transfer of table information and outstanding tasks to another staff member.

hold

A request to delay a specified order or course, not cancel it.

ingredient list

A record of ingredients used in a food product or recipe.

itemized bill

A bill showing separate dishes, drinks, and other charges.

modifier

An order detail that changes the standard dish, such as sauce on the side.

open check

A bill that has not yet been settled or closed.

place setting

The tableware arranged for one diner.

pre-bus

Remove used items during a meal after checking that diners have finished with them.

read-back

A spoken repetition of an order so the guest can correct it.

remake

A newly prepared replacement for a dish that needs correction.

replacement

An item supplied in place of another item.

seat number

A numbered position at a table used to match an order to a diner.

section

A group of tables assigned to a server for a period of service.

separate checks

Individual bills for different diners or groups at the same table.

service charge

A charge added for service under the restaurant's stated policy, distinct from an optional extra tip.

service recovery

Actions taken to address a service problem and restore the guest's confidence.

set menu

A group of courses offered together for a stated price and stated choices.

sharing plate

A plate provided so a diner can take a portion of a shared dish.

side dish

A smaller dish served alongside the main dish.

side work

Support tasks outside direct table service, such as restocking napkins.

split payment

Payment of one bill using more than one payment contribution.

supplement

An extra charge for a specified menu choice.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Attach each change to a dish

Was ___ for your ___ or for ___?

I have ___ for seat ___, with ___.

You're still deciding on ___; is that right?

A modifier needs a dish and a diner. 'On the side' means separately, not omitted. Ask a focused question before reading back the order.

Word combinations in this lesson

take an order: record what each diner requests

confirm the seat number: match the dish to the correct diner

put the sauce on the side: request a separate serving of sauce

read the order back: repeat the details before sending them

Explain what the price includes

___ costs ___ and includes ___.

The supplement brings the total to ___.

___ includes ___, whereas ___ does not.

Name the base price, any supplement, and what comes with each option. 'Whereas' introduces a contrast; it does not explain a cause.

Word combinations in this lesson

quote the supplement: state the extra charge for a menu choice

include a side: provide an accompaniment within the stated price

choose from the set menu: select within a grouped meal offer

compare like for like: compare options with the same included items

Separate a description from a suitability claim

You mentioned an allergy to ____.

I haven't confirmed ____ for this item.

The kitchen lead can check ____ before you decide.

A menu description may omit ingredients. 'Not listed' differs from 'not present.' Keep ingredient information separate from cross-contact questions.

Word combinations in this lesson

flag an allergy: make the guest's stated allergy clearly visible to the responsible team

check the current ingredients: consult information for the actual item being served

relay the exact concern: pass on the guest's stated question accurately

avoid a blanket assurance: do not claim every preparation is suitable

Give an estimate with a reference point

As of ____, the estimate is another ____.

____ is ready; ____ is still being prepared.

Does that leave enough time for ____?

Say when the estimate was obtained and whether it means additional time. Do not confuse 'held' with 'canceled' or 'being prepared' with 'ready'.

Word combinations in this lesson

fire the mains: ask the kitchen to begin the main course

hold the next course: delay the next stage of the meal

check the ticket time: find when the order entered the kitchen

give a revised estimate: state the kitchen's updated approximate wait

Correct the order and offer a choice

You ordered ____, but we brought ____.

The replacement would take approximately ____.

Would you like ____, or would you prefer to speak with ____?

A useful apology names the error. Give the available option and its wait before asking for a choice; a replacement isn't automatically a refund.

Word combinations in this lesson

acknowledge the mix-up: recognize that an order was confused

offer a replacement: propose another item within the options available

check back with the table: ask whether the correction addressed the concern

describe the mismatch: name how the served dish differs from the order

Check the meaning of 'split'

Would you like equal shares or ___?

This charge refers to ___ on the bill.

Before payment, could we confirm ___?

'Three ways' doesn't identify a division method. Confirm the method and visible charges before presenting the payment request; never ask learners to handle card credentials.

Word combinations in this lesson

split the bill evenly: divide the amount into equal shares

allocate an item: place a specific charge on a particular check

query a charge: ask why an amount appears on the bill

bring a corrected bill: provide an updated statement after an error is confirmed

Ask about use, not appearance

Are you finished with ___?

Shall I leave ___ for now?

May I reach across to remove ___?

An empty plate may still be in use. Use 'finished with' for an object; 'finished eating' asks about the person's meal.

Word combinations in this lesson

clear an empty plate: remove a plate the diner has finished using

leave the serving dish: keep the shared dish on the table

reset a place: arrange tableware for the next diner or course

ask before reaching: get the guest's attention before entering their table space

Transfer unresolved table details

Table ___ has ___; ___ is still open.

Please check ___ before ___.

Can you take over ___ while I ___?

Separate an open question from a completed action. A handover needs a receiver, not merely a note left at the station.

Word combinations in this lesson

take over a section: accept responsibility for specified tables

settle an open check: complete payment for an outstanding bill

restock the service station: replenish supplies used by servers

follow up on a request: return to an unresolved guest need

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Confirming seats and order details

Table 12 has three covers. Seat one orders mushroom pasta, seat two orders a salad with dressing separately, and seat three has not chosen. The phrase 'no onions' was spoken without a clear seat reference. Clarify before sending the order.

Before I send table twelve's order, could I check who requested no onions? I have mushroom pasta for seat one and a salad with dressing on the side for seat two. Seat three is still deciding. I'll attach the onion request to the correct dish and read those details back.

Try it again: Seat one also wants dressing for a side salad. Keep that request separate from seat two's main salad.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Explaining menu choices and prices

The fictional lunch set costs \$24 and includes a main and dessert. Steak adds a \$5 supplement. The a la carte steak is \$27 without dessert. Both steak options include potatoes. Explain the \$29 set steak option versus \$27 steak alone.

The steak set would be twenty-nine dollars: the twenty-four-dollar set price plus a five-dollar supplement. It includes dessert and potatoes. The a la carte steak is twenty-seven dollars with potatoes but no dessert. If you don't want dessert, the separate steak costs less; the set includes the extra course.

Try it again: The guest says 'So both are twenty-four dollars?' Correct the total without restarting the whole menu explanation.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Receiving an allergy question

A guest at table 6 reports a sesame allergy and asks about a bun. The server has an old menu description, not current ingredient or cross-contact information. The kitchen lead is available to discuss the question before any order is sent.

Thank you for telling me about your sesame allergy. The old menu description doesn't establish the current bun's ingredients or how it is handled. I can't confirm suitability from that description. I'll ask the kitchen lead to check your specific question before sending a food order, and bring back the verified information.

Try it again: The guest says they ate the bun last month. Explain why the current item still needs checking.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Coordinating courses and delays

Table 14 finished starters. Their mains were fired at 7:20. At 7:30 the kitchen estimates another eight minutes; one dish is still being prepared. The guests need to leave at 7:50. State the estimate and offer a timing discussion without guaranteeing completion.

We asked the kitchen to start your mains at seven twenty. One dish is still being prepared, and the current estimate is another eight minutes. I know you need to leave at seven fifty. That is an estimate, not a guaranteed serving time; would you like me to discuss your timing with the kitchen?

Try it again: The estimate changes to twelve more minutes. Report the change and ask whether the guest wants available alternatives discussed.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Correcting a dish without blame

Table 3 ordered vegetable pasta but received mushroom risotto. The ticket confirms pasta. The kitchen offers a pasta remake with an estimated ten-minute wait. The server may offer that replacement, but any bill adjustment needs the shift lead's review.

I'm sorry we brought risotto when your order was vegetable pasta. I've checked the ticket, and it does show pasta. The kitchen can remake it, with an estimated ten-minute wait. Would that work for you? If you want to discuss a bill adjustment, I'll ask our shift lead rather than promise one myself.

Try it again: The guest declines a replacement. Accept the choice and bring the shift lead into the bill discussion.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Explaining and splitting a bill

Three diners have a fictional \$72 total with all listed charges included. They request 'three ways': this could mean equal payments or separate checks by item. The restaurant supports either before payment. Ask which they mean; equal shares would be \$24.

When you say three ways, would you like three equal payments or separate checks for each person's items? The total shown is seventy-two dollars, including the listed charges. Equal payments would be twenty-four dollars each. If you prefer separate checks, I'll confirm who had each item before any payment is taken.

Try it again: The guests disagree over the shared dessert. Ask for their agreed allocation rather than choose for them.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Agreeing on clearing and shared service

At table 2, one diner's plate is empty but the shared vegetable dish still has food. The diner is using the plate for another portion. Ask what can be cleared; offer extra sharing plates without removing active items.

May I clear the empty glasses, or are you still using them? I'll leave your plate and the shared vegetables because you're taking another portion. Would an extra sharing plate help? I can bring one and then check which serving items you're finished with, without interrupting the rest of your meal.

Try it again: The guest says 'take those' while pointing between glasses and plates. Clarify the items.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Handing over a live section

At 8:00 Maya takes over tables 4 and 5. Table 4's mains are served, and dessert has not been ordered. Table 5 has an open check and a pending duplicate-coffee query being reviewed by the shift lead. Ask Maya to accept both follow-ups.

Maya, table four has its mains and hasn't ordered dessert. Table five's check is still open because the shift lead is reviewing a possible duplicate coffee charge. Please check on four's dessert preference and get the lead's decision before presenting five's bill again. Can you take those two follow-ups while I finish the station restock?

Try it again: The shift lead has not decided about the coffee charge. Keep the question open while accepting follow-up.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

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Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook: Waiters and Waitresses

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/food-preparation-and-serving/waiters-and-waitresses.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Waiters and Waitresses

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/35-3031.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Guided message practice gives four choices with explained feedback. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

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Lesson 01: Confirming seats and order details

Original fictional case: Table 12 has three covers. Seat one orders mushroom pasta, seat two orders a salad with dressing separately, and seat three has not chosen. The phrase 'no onions' was spoken without a clear seat reference. Clarify before sending the order.

Language workshop: Attach each change to a dish

Communication goal: Clarify an ambiguous modifier and confirm the complete order.

Language guidance: A modifier needs a dish and a diner. 'On the side' means separately, not omitted. Ask a focused question before reading back the order.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Was ___ for your ___ or for ___? / I have ___ for seat ___, with ___. / You're still deciding on ___; is that right?

Vocabulary: cover: One diner counted for restaurant table service. / seat number: A numbered position at a table used to match an order to a diner. / modifier: An order detail that changes the standard dish, such as sauce on the side. / read-back: A spoken repetition of an order so the guest can correct it.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest at seat two: confirm that no onions applies to your salad, not the pasta. Seat three needs another minute.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: Seat one also wants dressing for a side salad. Keep that request separate from seat two's main salad.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Before I send table twelve's order, could I check who requested no onions? I have mushroom pasta for seat one and a salad with dressing on the side for seat two. Seat three is still deciding. I'll attach the onion request to the correct dish and read those details back.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Retrieve occupational vocabulary

1. Select four terms from the reference. Explain each in plain English, give two natural collocations and quote or create a short workplace example. Label invented examples. Contrast each term with a plausible confusable term; acknowledge regional variation.
2. Present one role-labelled exchange with one missing word or phrase and four choices A-D. Exactly one choice must fit the stated facts and grammar. Stop and wait for my answer before revealing it.
3. Explain all four options, then invite me to read the completed exchange aloud. Offer a sentence frame for optional spoken practice, never an open-ended writing assignment.
4. Repeat for the other three terms, one question at a time. Vary the correct letter and the situation; preserve the reference facts. If a choice is ambiguous, replace the item.
5. Finish with two new four-choice collocation questions for later review, with a clearly separate answer key. Do not claim to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Test recall and transfer

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Review with supported choices and speaking

1. Ask me to close my notes. Prepare six four-choice questions: two vocabulary gaps, one grammar contrast, one confirmed-versus-unknown distinction, one choice of reply, and one transfer to a clearly labelled fictional variation.
2. Show only the first question. Use a short role-labelled exchange or a concrete scenario, four plausible choices A-D, and exactly one defensible answer. Stop and wait.
3. After each answer explain all options, offer one hint for a retry if needed, and invite me to say the completed exchange aloud. Only then move on. Do not request an original written response.
4. Track whether I answered independently or with a hint, not a certified proficiency score. Do not assess pronunciation from typed text. Replace ambiguous questions and accept valid spoken alternatives.
5. Give a compact review card with three four-choice recall items and a separate answer section. Summarize two specific successes and two points to revisit. Do not claim to remember or schedule future sessions.

END PROMPT